



Keen eye: B.J. Miller noticed how players would approach the net and get cleanly passed by a ball that was only one step and a reach away from them. This prompted him to look into the split step.

and shows how the ideal split step would enable these players to better deal with the increasing speed of the game. He encourages players and coaches to experiment with the ideal split step and describes a simple way to do so, whilst developing it as a habit.

What sparked your interest in the split step?

My interest started with Michael Wayman, a former touring pro and three-time West Coast Conference coach of the year at Saint Mary's College in Moraga, California. For years, I took lessons from him. He convinced me that even the best strokes would prove ineffective if a player was not prepared to execute those strokes.

Years later, while watching televised tennis matches, I noticed something strange. Players would

approach the net and get cleanly passed by a ball that was only one step and a reach away from them. Commentators would say, "Great passing shot!" I remember seeing 6'10" John Isner aced by a serve in the deuce court that landed in the corner of the box. Because Long John could probably take one step to his right and sign autographs in the first row, I was mystified that he wasn't able to reach that ball. It seemed like a preparation problem to me.

How did you start solving this mystery?

I began replaying points like these in slow motion. It seemed that players were in the air, unable to push off towards the ball, as it approached. When I recorded these situations in slow motion, I could see what the problem was. Players were airborne, out of contact with the ground, as the ball approached, making them unable to push off towards the oncoming ball until they landed. Their split step was leaving them unprepared to execute a volley.

I searched through videos of most of the top 100 players on the ATP and WTA tours. I found no one who was

not airborne at the instant their opponent hit the ball. Some players were not airborne some of the time, but none were consistently grounded as the ball approached.

What did you conclude?

I thought they must be doing this correctly. After all, these are the best players in the world. I checked several instructional tennis videos. Almost every one of them advocated being in the air when the opponent hit the ball. I thought maybe they would not have time to detect the direction of the oncoming ball if they landed their split step earlier, say, just as the opponent hit the ball. So, I — a successful senior tournament player — went out on the court with a hitting partner. He stood at the baseline. I was positioned at the net. I asked him to hit groundstrokes to me, and I would volley them. It took a few minutes to be able to land my split step precisely on the hit of his ball. When I did, it felt like I had a lot more time to execute a volley. I was turning into the hitting position for each volley as soon as my opponent hit the ball, as Wayman had instructed.